civil society groups and people working in the unorganized sector. Mohan Gopal was assigned the task.

Several meetings were organized with prominent NGOs as well as informal sector groups like railway porters, fisherfolk, rickshaw pullers, stonecutters, street vendors and anganwadi workers. ‘It was a unique exercise in the history of Indian politics. For the first time, a leader was engaging with those who had been marginal to decision-making. Through this one gesture, we could activate hundreds of NGOs and gain enormous goodwill,’ Gopal later told me.

In theory, he may have had a point. In reality, high inflation and low growth meant that Team Rahul’s target audience—those who were just above the poverty line and yet not quite middle class—was also feeling the squeeze. Modi’s promise of a return to a high-growth economy was attractive to this social group. ‘We were offering them a New Deal based on legal rights; Modi was using this aspirational class for a fascist takeover,’ is how Gopal tries to draw a contrast between Rahul and Modi’s approach.

The fact is, the Congress needed to make a strong comeback in an election in which they were trailing. The Rahul interview had been a disaster and the party was trying to desperately reposition their leader. Every time Rahul carried out a public interaction, a hapless member of the Congress media cell would call us and plead, ‘Please cut live—it will be very interesting.’ Sadly, it wasn’t.

The interactions were somehow wooden and scripted, an attempt by Rahul to do an Aamir Khan in *Satyamev Jayate* by talking to ‘real India’, but defeated by his own self-consciousness. Aamir’s show worked because of its clever positioning as an alternative to regular television entertainment shows. The viewer had tired of soaps and reality shows, and was looking for something different. Rahul’s addas didn’t catch the eye because he was sermonizing and theorizing at a time when the nation wanted answers to the burning issues of the day—from price rise to corruption.

Yes, there was the odd lively exchange. For example, Rahul had a passionate debate with railway coolies. But it was all too brief and clearly wasn’t enough to alter the course of the political debate. Rahul’s own